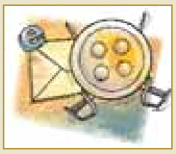
Anti-virus for E-mail



Most anti-virus software use a mail proxy to scan your incoming and outgoing mail. The software re-routes your mail through its own internal engine before it reaches the e-mail client, which gives it a chance to clean up, or stop the mail there if it's infected. You can use just about any POP3 client to access mail through one of these anti-virus proxies.

Most of these tools leave the entire configuration to the mail client side without needing any configuration on the software, since they act as a proxy that can be turned on or off. Let's see how this works. You have an account from ISP1, the POP3 mail server name is pop.isp1.net.in, your login name is 'user1', and password is 'anypassword'. This is your configuration for your ISP when you connect directly.

When you use a proxy, the settings mentioned above change to this format:

1. POP3 Server name changes to 'localhost' or '127.0.0.1' which is a loop back IP to your own machine. As the proxy runs on your own machine, it attaches itself to the local loop back IP.

2. Your username changes to 'user1#pop.isp1.net.in', where '#' is a separator character that separates the username from the server name. This is different in case of every anti-virus software (Norton AntiVirus uses '/' as a separator). This is how your anti-virus proxy gets the path from where it retrieves mail.

3. Password remains unchanged; it's the same as the password you use on the server. Every time you change your password on the server, remember to enter the new password in your mail client.

That's it! You're done! If your anti-virus supports an outgoing mail proxy as well, you will set your outgoing SMTP server to 'localhost' or '127.0.0.1'.

through unsolicited mail which are accompanied by attachments.

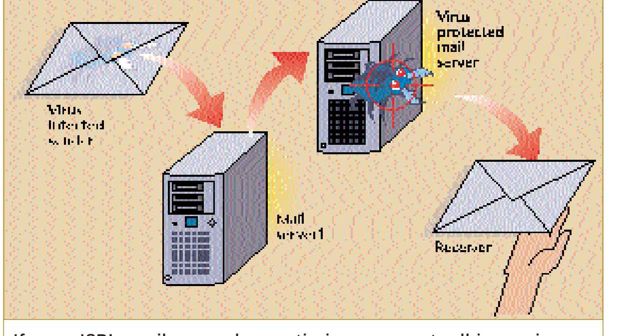
The Melissa worm which struck in 1999 dispelled any notions of e-mail being a secure environment. Melissa exploited Microsoft's scripting language (Visual Basic for Applications) to send a copy of the e-mail to very person in the recipient's address book. Later worms such as Iloveyou and Sircam followed in the same fashion. E-mail viruses are thus able to propagate themselves at a pace that anti-virus software developers just can't match up with.

The vulnerability of certain e-mail clients just adds to the misery. For instance, one of the worms spread by exploiting the preview pane option in Outlook Express, while another used the Signatures tab. In both instances, if you disabled the preview pane or signature attachments, the worm did not spread. ActiveX scripts and exploits based on these became another source of worry soon afterwards.

While a simple precaution against viruses can be that you make sure to scan all attachments before opening them, the spread of Nimda virus has raised new issues as it uses exploits in such a fashion that it does away with the concept of opening attachments—just reading the e-mail is enough for the virus to start on its destructive path.

Some anti-virus software such as AVG, Norton AntiVirus, QuickHeal, etc, allow for automatically scanning an e-mail before you read it, and thus ensure one level of protection. Web-based e-mail services such as Hotmail also scan all attachments, thereby adding to the level of protection for people who do not use local e-mail clients.

Anti-virus Mail Server



If your ISP's mail server has anti-virus support, all incoming mail will be automatically scanned for malicious code. If any viruses are found, the mail would be deleted/quarantined and a notice would be sent to you

Internet

As the Nimda virus proved, just visiting a Web site may often be enough for the virus to spread. Even otherwise, Web sites with ActiveX scripting and Java applets can prove to be dangerous. Anti-virus software such as McAfee have a list of malicious sites that it keeps track off and you can also add sites to this list.

Chatting using your Instant Messenger clients may seem a totally innocuous function, but one virus was known to spread through MSN Messenger. Again, most of us send and receive files using instant messenger and are quite careless about it. We don't realise that these files have to be treated with the same degree of apprehension as an e-mail attachment—that is, you need to scan these files before opening them.

Likewise, scripts and bots on many of the IRC sites act as Trojans to infect your system. Even the newer P2P programs such as Morpheus, eDonkey 2000 or Gnutella are becoming one of the major sources of viruses. It's quite possible in P2P programs to have an executable renamed with an MP3 extension. It's not tough to lure you into downloading the file, is it?

Storage media

The usual modes of transfer are through infected files that are transferred and opened on other PCs and infected floppies. Thus, from one computer it extends its residency to many others, without the user's knowledge. At one

Internet Safety Rules

- Disable ActiveX and Java Virtual Machine unless you really need it
- Do not keep the settings in your Instant Messenger or IRC client for auto-download. It should prompt you before downloading. If you don't normally transfer files, you can disable this option
- Any setting that allows a stranger to contact you over chat and send files to you should be disabled
- Integrate your download managers with an anti-virus utility so that the moment the download is complete, the files get automatically scanned